RUTGERS

Pragmatics I

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Please pick up your **name card** from the front

office hours: Mondays, 2:00-3:00 pm

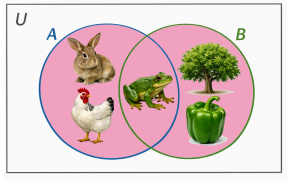
Basement, Room 003, **Linguistics Building**

Previously on 201: Set Operations

union (∪)

$A \cup B = \{ x \in U \mid x \in A \text{ or } x \in B \}$

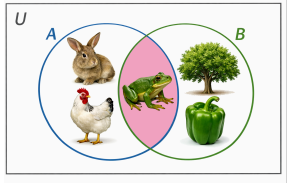
(elements in A or B or *both*)



intersection (∩)

$A \cap B = \{ x \in U \mid x \in A \text{ and } x \in B \}$

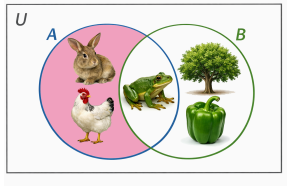
(elements in both A and B)



difference (–)

$A - B = \{ x \in U \mid x \in A \text{ and } x \notin B \}$

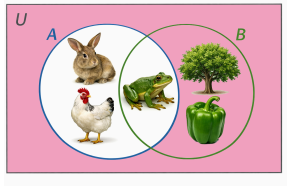
(elements in A but not B)



complement (')

$A' = \{ x \in U \mid x \notin A \}$

(elements in U but not A)



Previously on 201: Set Theory in Languages

Snoopy is a white dog.

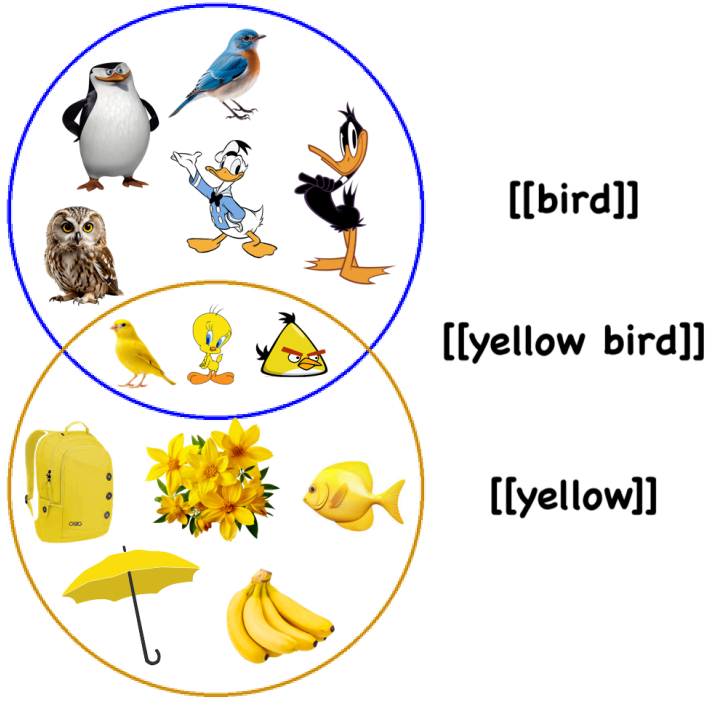
⬇

[[Snoopy]] ∈ [[white]] ∩ [[dog]]

Yellow birds are pretty.

⬇

[[yellow]] ∩ [[bird]] ⊆ [[pretty]]



- note that set operators (∪, ∩, –, ′) **take precedence over** set relation symbols (∈, ⊆, =)
- compare this to arithmetic operators (+, –, ×, ÷) and (in)equality symbols (=, <, >) in algebra

Previously on 201: Quantifiers

- sentences with **quantifiers** involve some quantity – **cardinality** of a set

Four cats are running.

- the **cardinality** of the intersection of [[cat]] and [[run]] is **four**
- in other words, there are **exactly four elements** that are both in [[cat]] and [[run]]

| [[cat]] ∩ [[run]] | = 4

quantifier	**example**	**set theory expression** (| [[N]] ∩ [[VP]] | = ?)	
numeral N VP	***Two*** *students run*.	| [[N]] ∩ [[VP]] | = n	(n specificed by numeral)
some N VP	***Some*** *students run*.	| [[N]] ∩ [[VP]] | ≠ 0	**or** [[N]] ∩ [[VP]] ≠ ∅
every N VP	***Every*** *student runs*.	| [[N]] ∩ [[VP]] | = | [[N]] |	**or** [[N]] ⊆ [[VP]] = TRUE
many N VP	***Many*** *students run*.	| [[N]] ∩ [[VP]] | > n	(n is some large number)
most N VP	***Most*** *students run*.	| [[N]] ∩ [[VP]] | > ½ | [[N]] |	
no N VP	***No*** *students run*.	| [[N]] ∩ [[VP]] | = 0	**or** [[N]] ∩ [[VP]] = ∅

Pragmatics

A Mysterious Note

- what information does this note provide?
- what information is **missing** for fully understanding the note?



- who is "me"? (who is writing?)
- who is the implied "you"? (who is written to?)
- where is "here"?
- when is "tomorrow"? (when is the note written and when iss the day after that?)

Pragmatics



- we have said that **Semantics** focuses on the literal meaning
- yet when we actually talk, we do **NOT** speak in a vacuum
- we also care about the **particular context**

1. particular **time**
2. particular **venue**
3. particular **situation**
4. with particular **people** that we have a particular **relationship** with (or don't)
5. within an **ongoing**conversation (in a **discourse**, not individual sentences)

Pragmatics

- **Pragmatics**, focuses on **implied meaning** and is the study of **language in context**

- in Pragmatics, we talk about **utterances** rather than **sentences**:

    - a **sentence**: is language used in a vacuum without reference to context

    - an **utterance** is language spoken in a particular context that informs meanings



Pragmatics

- **Pragmatics**, focuses on **implied meaning** and is the study of **language in context**
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  - a **sentence**: is language used in a vacuum without reference to context
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two types of **implied meaning** will be introduced

conversational implicatures, implied meaning that arises when speakers follow (or ignore) the common rules of conversation

- **presuppositions** (revisit), the background information that is taken for granted when saying an utterance

Pragmatics: Speech Acts and Politeness Strategies

Pragmatics studies many aspects of language **in context**, for instance

speech act

- most language communicates an idea, asks a question, gives a command...
- so we take an action simply by saying something, so the language that does something is called a **speech act**

1. **a rookie**: *Roger that, sir!*
2. **officiator**: *I now pronounce you married.*
3. **King Arthur**: *For the love of Camelot!*

politeness strategies

- **Kazakh**: two words for 'you', familiar *sen* and polite *siz*, part of knowing Kazakh is knowing **when** to use which pronoun
- **Japanese**: a person named Kentaro Tanaka might be called *Ken-chan*, *Tanaka-san*, *Tanaka-sama*, *Tanaka-sensei*, etc. depending on their relationship to the speaker
- **English**: *'Sup!* is used mostly in casual situation

Pragmatics vs. Semantics

Arthur: **Do you want to go out tonight?**
Merlin: **I have an exam tomorrow.**

- **Semantics** studies **literal meaning**
  - meanings that can be defined with truth values or calculated with set theory expressions
  - literal meaning: Merlin has an exam
- **Pragmatics** studies **implied meaning**
  - meanings that rely on **context** for interpretation
  - implied meaning: Merlin can't or doesn't want to go out



Pragmatics vs. Semantics

in semantics, we discussed **relations** between sentences and we saw that some sentences can **entails** or **presuppose** other sentences

P **entails** Q iff: whenever P is **TRUE**, Q is also **TRUE**

P **presupposes** Q iff: both P and the negation of P **entail** Q

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(a) *Lancelot opened his umbrella*.
(b) *it was raining outside*.

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(a) *Lancelot opened his umbrella*.
(b) *it was raining outside*.

if we only consider the **literal meaning**, (a) does **NOT** entai (b), even though common sense might tell us that (a) is likely due to (b)

Implicature

A New Inference

- Arthur: **Is it raining outside?**
- Merlin: **(well,) Lancelot opened his umbrella.**

- Arthur's utterance neither **entails** nor **presupposes** Merlin's utterance
- but Merlin's utterance does have an **inference** that it is raining outside (and that is why Lancelot opened his umbrella)

A New Inference

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- Arthur's utterance neither **entails** nor **presupposes** Merlin's utterance
- but Merlin's utterance does have an **inference** that it is raining outside (and that is why Lancelot opened his umbrella)

- we call this inference **implicature**
- informally, an **implicature** is an inference that: is **"suggested" by** an utterance, and is **NOT entailed** by the utterance

Implicature

- Arthur: **Is it raining outside?**
- Merlin: **(well,) Lancelot opened his umbrella.**

if Merlin's utterance is an implicature of Arthur's, we may want to ask:

1. why are there **implicatures**?
2. where do **implicatures** come from?

or more specifically, we want to know

- how Arthur derives the inference that '*it is raining outside*', from what Merlin has said

Implicature

- Arthur: **Is it raining outside?**
- Merlin: **(well,) Lancelot opened his umbrella.**

- intuitively, Arthur might go through a **chain of thought** roughly like this

1. let's assume that Merlin is trying to have a **genuine** conversation (and he's not just trying to joke with John);
2. **based on this assumption**, Merlin should **NOT** say things that are **irrelevant** to the conversation
3. so what he said '*Lancelot opened his umbrella.*' should be **relevant**
4. the answer to Arthur's question is literally either '*Yes, it is raining outside.*' or '*No, it is not raining outside.*'
5. if Merlin's utterance is **not irrelevant**, then it must be **related to** the possible answers (relation built)

conclusion: '*Lancelot opened his umbrella.*' must **implicate** '*it is raining outside.*'

Implicature

- **Morgana: Did you mow the grass and wash the car like I told you to?**

- **Modred: I mowed the grass.**

implicature of Modred's utterance

Modred did not wash the car.

- **Parceval: Did you make a doctor's appointment?**

- **Gawain: Their line was busy.**

implicature of Gawain's utterance

Modred did not make the oppointment.

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from all of these conversations, we say that the second speaker **is trying to have a genuine conversation**

the first speaker automatically **assumes** that the second speaker (hearer) will reply

adhering to the rules of conversation

The Cooperative Principle

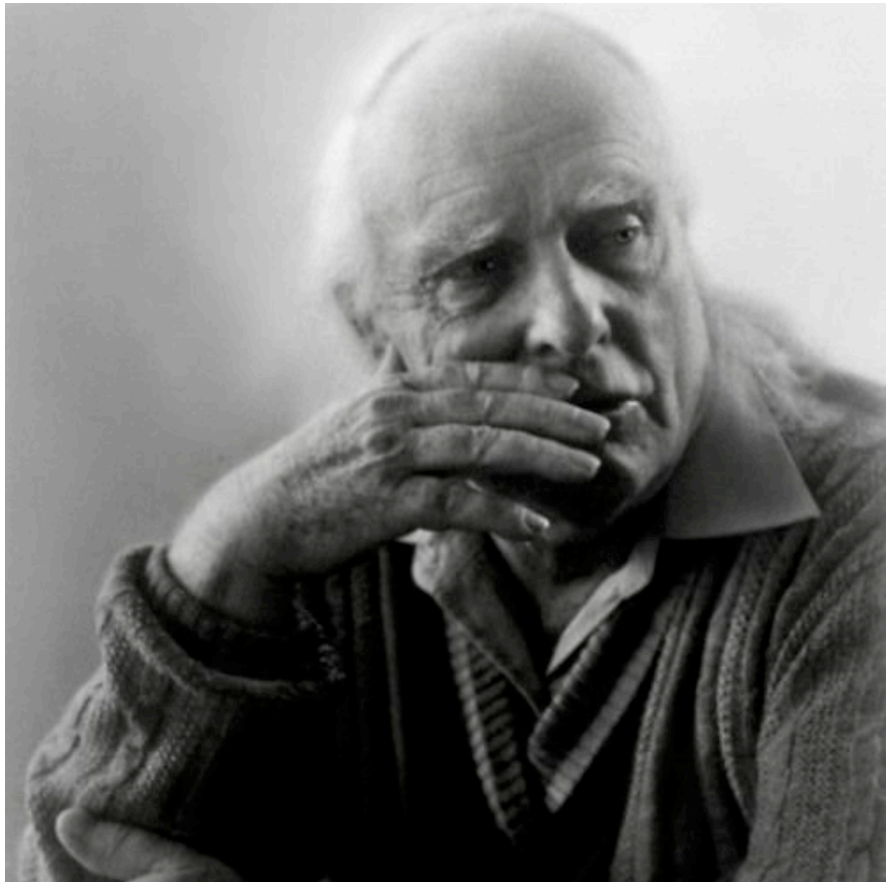
- philosopher **Paul Grice** studied how people behave when they're having a conversation

- participants in a conversation (**interlocutors**) tend to collaborate and follow certain rules:

1. **NOT** saying things that are **irrelevant**
   – *How are you today?*
   – *false*.

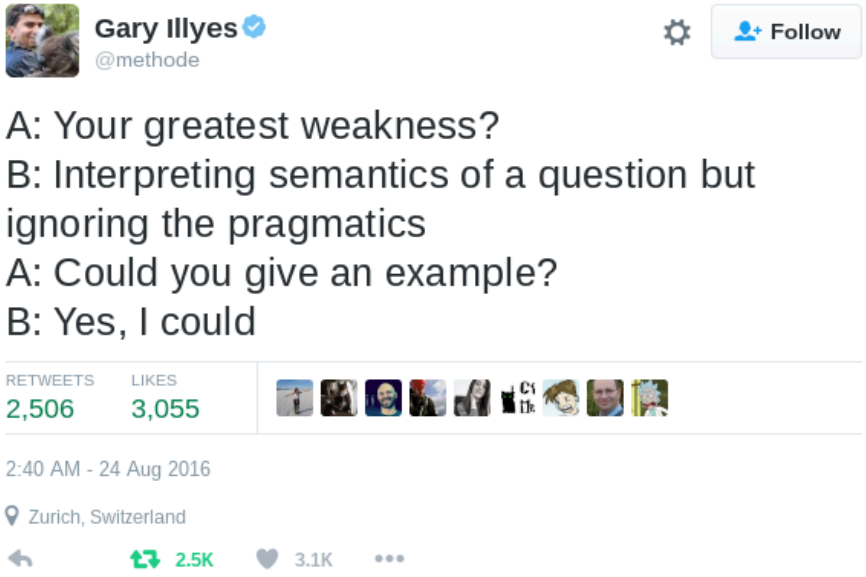
2. **NOT** saying things are believed to be **false**
   – *Do you know where the truck is?*
   – *On the top of my head*.

3. **NOT** saying **more** or **less** than needed
   – *Do you fancy a cuppa tea or coffee?*
   – *Yes*.



Paul Grice (1913-1988)

The Cooperative Principle



- these rules of conversation is called the **Cooperative Principle**
- we tend to behave **cooperative** whenever we're collaborating on a common task with a common goal with other people
- this sounds like a big ask, but people are actually pretty good at it (**subconsciously**)
- people are said to be cooperative when they follow the **conversational maxims**

participants in a conversation tend to say what's **appropriate** for the situation and goals of the conversation


HOW WAS YOUR DAY, JEREMY?
'K
TELL ME ALL ABOUT SCHOOL...EVERY DETAIL!
WELL, IT'S A BIG BUILDING..
OKAY, EVERY OTHER DETAIL.

Grice's Maxims



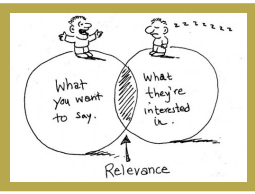
Maxim of Quality
be truthful

- don't say what you believe to be false
- don't say what you don't have evidence for



Maxim of Quantity
be informative as needed

- don't say more than you need to
- don't say less than you need to



Maxim of Relation (Relevance)
be relevant

- don't say irrelevant things



Maxim of Manner
be clear

- don't be obscure, ambiguous or wordy
- provide information in a **sensible** order

although they're worded like commands, the maxims are intended to describe how people **tend** to behave or are **assumed** to behave, not how they **ought to** behave

Provide Information in a SENSIBLE Order

what was reported in the news:

1. Arthur resigned.
2. The company decided to launch an investigation into him.

what actually happened:

1. The company decided to launch an investigation into him.
2. Arthur resigned.





Sometimes We Break (Flout) the Maxims

- we generally assume interlocutors are following the **Cooperative Principle** and **conversational maxims**

- yet, sometimes it **seems** we break the maxims:
  - Lancelot: *How was the dinner?*
  - Percival: *I wish I stayed home*.

- Percival said something **irrelevant** to the dinner, flouting the **Maxim of Relevance**

- what if Percival is in fact being **cooperative**?
  - *(The dinner was bad/not that good, so) I wish I stayed home*.



conversational implicature can be arised when the interlocuter **intentionally** flouts the maxims (they are still cooperative), in this case, Percival's utterance **implicates** that '*the dinner was bad*'

Maxim of Quality

maxim of quality: be truthful

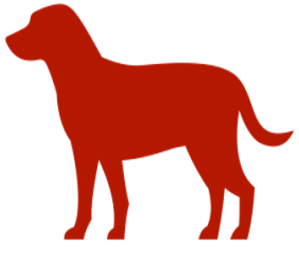
- do **not** say what you believe to be **false**
  - not everything is a lie in a conversation
- do **not** say that for which you **lack adequate evidence**
- "adequate evidence" depends on the situation
  - a doctor would be held to a **higher standard of evidence** than a regular person on a disease outcome

obeying the maxim

Did you break my bowl?



Sorry, it was me. I got too excited chasing a tennis ball.



Maxim of Quality

maxim of quality: be truthful

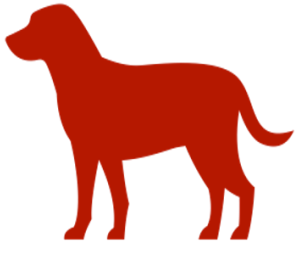
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flouting the maxim

Dogs can fly, right?



And cats can swim in the outer space, I suppose.



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- "adequate evidence" depends on the situation
  - a doctor would be held to a **higher standard of evidence** than a regular person on a disease outcome
- **note** here that an **implicature** is not what is literally said

flouting the maxim

Dogs can fly, right?

And cats can swim in the outer space, I suppose.

implicature: The cat's statement is wildly wrong.

if we assume the dog is **cooperative**, dog's saying obviously false things **implicate** that the cat's statement is absurd

Notes on Violation or Flouting

- we **DO** have cases where people **violate** or **ignore** the **maxims**
- **lying** and **claiming without evidence** would be **violating** maxim of quality
- sometimes, **flouting** a maxim is done to convey additional message for sarcastic or comedic effect
  - A: *My TA gave me 59 as the final grade intentionally just to fail me*!
  - B: *What a lovely and responsible TA he is!*
- hence, **intentionally** flouting the maxim will arise an **implicature**



Maxim of Quantity

maxim of quantity: be informative as needed

- be as **informative** as is required
- do not be either **over**informative or **under**informative
- this maxim calls for an **appropriate** amount of information

obeying the maxim

What languages do you speak?

I speak English, Kazakh and Mandarin.





Maxim of Quantity

maxim of quantity: be informative as needed

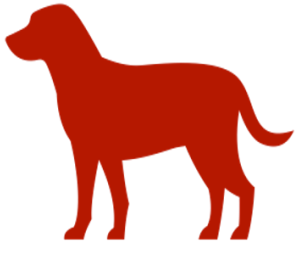
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- for the utterance on the right, if the dog also speaks German
  - is the utterance still true?
  - how does the utterance sound?

flouting the maxim

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I speak English, Kazakh, German and Mandarin.





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  - how does the utterance sound?

flouting the maxim

What languages do you speak?	I speak English, Kazakh, German and Mandarin.

implicature (possible): The dog does not want to let the cat know that he speaks German as well.

if we assume the dog is **cooperative**, dog's intentionally hiding things **implicate** that he thinks it is not necessary to tell the cat about this case

Maxim of Quantity

Judge: *Mr. Lachinskaya, have you pleaded guilty to all of the charges listed before this court?*

Mr. L: *I admit to the first one, Your Honor*.

what is Mr. lachinskaya **implicating**?

Arthur: *What do you do for a living?*

Merlin: *I work*.

what is probably **implicated** Merlin via flouting the **maxim of quantity**?

Maxim of Quantity: Scalar Implicature

maxim of quantity: be informative as needed

- **scalar implicature** is a special type of quantity implicature
  - *Some students passed the exam.*
- **literal** meaning
  - ⟦student⟧ ∩ ⟦passed the exam⟧ ≠ ∅
- **implicature**: *Not all students passed the exam.*
  - if *all* students passed
  - since *all* is a stronger statement compared to *some*
  - assuming I'm adhering to Maxim of Quantity, I **would have** just used *all*
  - but I **intentionally** used *some*

obeying the maxim

Did you eat the cookies?

I ate **some of** them.





Maxim of Quantity: Scalar Implicature

maxim of quantity: be informative as needed

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obeying the maxim

Did you eat the cookies?

I ate **some of** them.

implicature (possible): The dog did not eat all cookies.

the dog is **cooperative**, and offering information that is as **informative** as needed, but he **intentionally** chose *weaker* statement (*some*), which **implicate** that he did not eat **all** cookies

Maxim of Relevance

maxim of relevance: be relevant

- it is generally assumed that people will say things **relevant to the current topic** of conversation

obeying the maxim

Our TA is nice, isn't he?



He is lovely and responsible.



Maxim of Relevance

maxim of relevance: be relevant

- it is generally assumed that people will say things **relevant to the current topic** of conversation

flouting the maxim

Our TA is nice, isn't he?



Cookies are pretty nice for sure.



Maxim of Relevance

maxim of relevance: be relevant

- it is generally assumed that people will say things **relevant to the current topic** of conversation
- we sometimes **CAN** change the topic without violating this **maxim**
- but we do need to **literally** signal the change of topic to our interlocutors
  - – Arthur: *How was the movie?*
    – Merlin: *Actually, there's something else I want to talk to you about*.
- Merlin is not being relevant, but he signaled his [illegible] to change the topic with "**actually**"

flouting the maxim

Our TA is nice, isn't he?	Cookies are pretty nice for sure.

implicature: The dog does not like the TA at all.

if we assume the dog is **cooperative**, dog's intentionally changing the topic things **implicate** that he does not agree with the cat

Maxim of Relevance



*we often rely on implied meanings like implicatures because it would be **rude** or **inappropriate** or even just overly **pedantic** to say everything literally*

- assuming that people are being **relevant** helps us make sens of people's utterances
- – Arthur: *Is Lancelot dating anyone these days?*
  – Merlin: *He goes to London every weekend*.
  - if Merlin (~~as always~~) makes sense (is being **relevant**), what is he **implicating**?
- a professor writes in the recommendation letter to a graduate programme for Merlin:
  - *Merlin has good handwriting and he always dresses neatly*
  - is it relevant?
  - what is the **implicature**?

Maxim of Manner

maxim of manner: be clear

- avoid **obscurity** of expression (don't be hard to understand)
- avoid **ambiguity**
- be **brief**. (don't be too wordy)
- be **orderly** (present information in an order that makes sense)

obeying the maxim

What did you do this morning?

A_1: I went to the park and had my breakfast.
A_2: I had my breakfast and went to the park.





Maxim of Manner

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- avoid **obscurity** of expression (don't be hard to understand)
- avoid **ambiguity**
- be **brief**. (don't be too wordy)
- be **orderly**. (present information in an order that makes sense)
  - *Arthur took the medication and had an allergic reaction*.
  - *Arthur had an allergic reaction and took the medication*.

obeying the maxim

What did you do this morning?

A_1: I went to the park and had my breakfast.
A_2: I had my breakfast and went to the park.

A_1's implicature: He had breakfast in the park.
A_2's implicature: He had breakfast at home.

if the dog is **cooperative**, his intentionally using different orders **implicate** the order of events

Exercise I: Grice's Maxims

identify the **conversational implicatures** in the following dialogues
identify the **maxims** that lead to each implicature

1. Merlin: Do you have our tickets with you?
   Arthur: Didn't I give it to you?

2. Merlin: How do you like the string quartet?
   Arthur: I think the violinist is good



what is this violating?

Exercise I: Grice's Maxims

identify the **conversational implicatures** in the following dialogues
identify the **maxims** that lead to each implicature

1. Merlin: Do you have our tickets with you?
   Arthur: Didn't I give it to you?
   - Arthur does not have the tickets.
   - Maxim of relevance (flouted)

2. Merlin: How do you like the string quartet?
   Arthur: I think the violinist is good
   - Arthur does not think the whole quartet is good
   - Maxim of quantity (flouted)



what is this violating?

- maxim of quality
- the original question was not **genuine**

Cancelling and Reinforcing Implicatures



- implicatures can be **cancelled** and **reinforced**, but literal meaning cannot
- what do the following utterances **implicate**?
  - – *What languages does Anna speak?*
    – *Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi*.
  - *Ian ate a cake and was happy*.
  - – *Does Sue have any siblings?*
    – *Sue has a brother*.

Cancelling and Reinforcing Implicatures



- implicatures can be **cancelled** and **reinforced**, but literal meaning cannot

- what do the following utterances **implicate**?

  - *– What languages does Anna speak?*
    – Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi.
  - ***implicature***: *Anna speaks only these three languages*.

  - *Ian ate a cake and was happy*.
  - ***implicature***: *Ian ate a cake and that made him happy*.

  - *– Does Sue have any siblings?*
    – Sue has a brother.
  - ***implicature***: *Sue has only one brother*.

Cancelling Implicatures

- what if we say the following sentence:

  Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi. ***In fact, she also speaks Greek***.

- implicatures can be **cancelled** or **defeated**: we add extra information to the statement that **contradicts** the **implicature** and makes it go away

Cancelling Implicatures

- what if we say the following sentence:

  Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi. ***In fact, she also speaks Greek***.

- implicatures can be **cancelled** or **defeated**: we add extra information to the statement that **contradicts** the **implicature** and makes it go away

- – *Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi*. *In fact, she also speaks Greek*.
  - ***implicature***: ~~*Anna speaks only these three languages*~~.

- – *Ian ate a cake and was happy*. *In fact, he ate the cake because he was happy*.
  - ***implicature***: ~~*Ian ate a cake and that made him happy*~~.

- – *Does Sue have any siblings?*.
  – *Sue has a brother*. *In fact, she has two brothers*.
  - ***implicature***: ~~*Sue has only one brother*~~.

Reinforcing Implicatures

- what if we say the following sentence:

  Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi. ***And she doesn't speak any others***.

- implicatures can be **reinforced** as well: we add extra information to the statement that **further supports** the **implicature** and makes it firmer

Reinforcing Implicatures

- what if we say the following sentence:

  Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi. ***And she doesn't speak any others***.

- implicatures can be **reinforced** as well: we add extra information to the statement that **further supports** the **implicature** and makes it firmer

- – *Anna speaks English, Korean, and Farsi*. *And she doesn't speak any others*.
  - ***implicature***: *Anna speaks only these three languages*. ✔

- – *Ian ate a cake and was happy*. *It was the cake that made him happy*.
  - ***implicature***: *Ian ate a cake and that made him happy*. ✔

- – *Does Sue have any siblings?*.
  – *Sue has a brother*, *and only one brother*.
  - ***implicature***: *Sue has only one brother*. ✔

Literal Meaning is NOT Cancellable/Reinforceable

- **cancelling** and **reinforcing** are important tests for literal **vs.** implied meaning
  - **literal meaning CANNOT** be cancelled or reinforced
  - but **implicatures CAN** be
- if we try to cancel the **literal meaning**
- *Merlin speaks English, Kazakh, and Mandarin*.
  - *but he does not speak Kazakh*.
    cancelling → contradiction
  - *and he speaks Kazakh*.
    reinforcing → redundancy

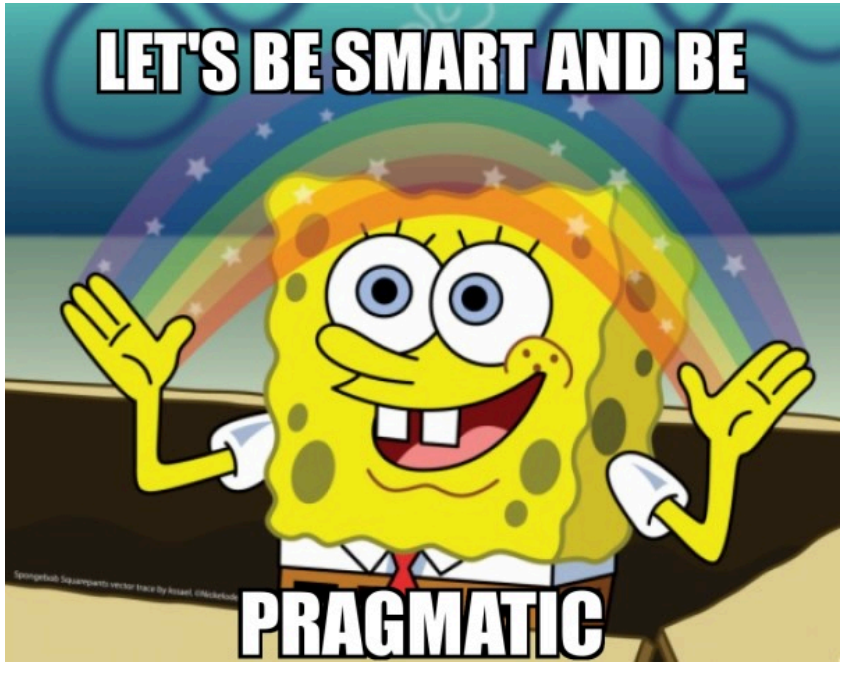


Exercise II: Implicature Cancelling/Reinforcing

for each sentence below, two additional statements are given – one is part of the sentence's literal meaning, one is an implicature, try to **reinforce/cancel** each statement to test whether it is **literal** or an **implicature**

1. **I drove home at noon**.
   A: I drove a car.
   B: I drove home during the day.

2. **I called 10 times and nobody picked up**.
   A: I called at least 5 times.
   B: I was using a phone.



Assignment V is due this Friday (**Nov 06**) at **11:59 pm**

Assignment VI will be published this Wednesday (**Nov 04**) and is due next Friday (**Nov 13**) at **11:59 pm**

continue reading: **Chapter 8: Pragmatics** of Griffiths & Cummins' (2017) *An Introduction to English Semantics and Pragmatics*



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